practices of democracy and repression, too. Each chapter of this book explores American cultural productions that were routed historically and conceptually through a divided Berlin. The chapters detail representations of the Berlin Wall and catalog the creative processes that led toward the production of a particular book about U.S. cultures of division and solidarity. Considerations of published works are interanimated with reflections gleaned from archives, encompassing materials from library collections, national holdings, oral histories, and private papers. The various Berlin Wall books exist in distinct genre forms—the photobook, the political autobiography, the conceptual art book, and the poetry collection—but overlap in their methods of production and patterns of critical discovery, whether produced inside or outside Berlin. While disciplinary readings in fields of cultural history, literary studies, or art history allow particular claims to be made within a given chapter, my project aims to "form an archive," as Andrew Friedman puts it in another context, "that arises from a landscape rather than a discipline."[24] Out of the archive of American Berliners' engagement with the border zones and occupied sectors surrounding the Wall, the cultural productions examined in these pages constitute a critical constellation of work made by Americans whose encounters in a walled Berlin led to projects directed at other sites of division.

By focusing on the individuals within networks of artistic and political engagement, this book demonstrates that the Berlin Wall reflected significant histories of social division beyond scripts of state authority and military strategy. U.S. artists, writers, and activists working in and through Berlin approached boundaries of freedom through a practice that Salamishah Tillet terms "critical patriotism" engaging sites of freedom and repression in a manner that "neither encourages idolatry to the nation's past nor blind loyalty to the state" but through "dissidence and dissent … re-engages the meta-discourse of American democracy."[25]

The American Berliners at the center of this book are intriguing not only for what they explored and created while the Wall stood; each returned to Berlin after its dismantling in 1989. Through their returns, they spark and extend historical questions through practices of cultural memory while back in then-reunified Berlin. Their work on the Berlin Wall builds on previous themes but remains an incomplete task; as they find productive points of